

Course guide for the Master's Thesis course

Master's Programme in Political Science

Master's Programme in Political Science: Environmental Governance and Behavior

SK2512 Master's Thesis, 15 credits

SK2532, Master's Thesis, 30 credits

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1. Course content and learning outcomes

During this course students will learn to write and orally defend an independent, in-depth scientific thesis. During the course, students will learn how to plan, carry out and present scientific research which incorporates all stages of the scientific process: from problem formulation to theory, scientific questions of relevance, method, presentation of results, and conclusions. Students will also present and defend their research and conclusions at a mandatory seminar, where they will receive critical and probing questions from both the opponent (another student) and the examiner. Students will also critically, constructively and pedagogically examine other students' theses in the same scientific manner. Students should display a critical and scientific approach in all these activities. The teaching on the course consists mainly of individual supervision. There are also introductory lectures and mandatory examination seminars.

On successful completion of the course, the student will be able to:

Knowledge and understanding

- Understand and independently apply scientific theoretical perspectives and methods in order to complete an original research project relevant to Political Science.

Competence and skills

- Creatively, critically and independently identify, formulate and delimit an original scientific question of relevance to Political Science.
- Creatively and independently select an appropriate methodological approach to answer a specified scientific question.

- Systematically gather and compile empirical data and/or identify and evaluate existing empirical data, sources or secondary literature.
- Produce a written report and orally present and defend it.
- Publicly discuss another student's degree project as well as participate in discussions regarding other students' degree projects.
- Independently produce text in accordance with good academic practice, including proper citation technique and use of references.
- Communicate clearly and proficiently in English both orally and in writing.

Judgement and approach

- Critically evaluate the reliability of conclusions and findings of academic research and policy evaluations.
- Identify and critically assess ethical issues related to research on human behaviour

2. Preparations before the Master's thesis course starts

Before the Master's thesis course begins, and alongside the preceding courses, there will be an introductory lecture and the assignment of supervisors. Students are required to submit an abstract outlining the topic of their thesis. Based on this abstract, the course coordinator will suggest a suitable supervisor for each student.

Students may also contact potential supervisors directly to request supervision. However, all agreements must be communicated to the course coordinator. If a student has not established contact with a supervisor by the start of the Master's thesis course, they must inform the course coordinator immediately.

The abstract should be around one page and include:

- The research problem
- The gap in the literature that your thesis aims to address
- The research question(s)
- Suggested research design/methodology

3. Supervision

Students are supervised by a teacher from the Department of Political Science. The supervisory relationship entails both rights and responsibilities. Students have the right to receive advice and support, but they also have an obligation to use the allocated supervision time - 20 hours in total - as constructively and effectively as possible.

To ensure productive meetings, students should submit any text they want feedback on in advance of meetings. Supervisors, in turn, are responsible for preparing for meetings by reading submitted texts and offering constructive comments and guidance. The exact timing and structure of supervision meetings should be agreed upon by the student and the supervisor. However, it is the student's responsibility to ensure that the supervisor has sufficient time to read and comment on the thesis before it is submitted for examination.

4. Examination seminars

A. Seminar attendance

The schedule for the examination seminars will be published on Canvas a few days after thesis submission. Students are encouraged to attend all seminars. Each student is required to present their own thesis at one seminar and to serve as an opponent at another student's seminar.

Each seminar is 90 minutes long, and typically four seminars are held per day. Students are not able to choose the date or time of their assigned seminar.

B. Seminar structure: the role of author and opponent

The seminar is divided into three main parts: (1) the author's presentation, (2) a Q&A and discussion between the author and the opponent, and (3) an oral examination conducted by the examiner.

The author presents what the thesis is about, its purpose and most central theoretical contribution, which method and material have been used, what the thesis results are, and how these results have contributed to our knowledge. The presentation should last 10-12 minutes. If the time limit is exceeded, the examiner will interrupt the presentation.

During the presentation of their thesis, the author may use one A4 page with bullet-point notes for support, but not a fully written-out presentation. The purpose of the presentation is for the author to demonstrate mastery of the subject and the ability to reflect on their contribution. The A4 page is handed to the examiner during the examination.

At the thesis examination, the opponent plays an important role alongside the author. After the author's presentation, the opponent has 30 minutes to discuss strength and weakness of the study in a constructive manner. The opponent selects which parts are particularly important to focus on during the opposition. Given the limited time, the opponent will need to carefully choose themes and questions. In general, opponents should consider the same criteria for evaluating theses as in Table 1 (see below), including:

- Are the aim and research question of the thesis relevant to scientific and policy debates and is this relevance clearly explained?
- Is the thesis well connected to previous research and theory? Does the thesis convince you that the research questions address a question not answered in this previous research?
- Are the questions of the study reasonable, presented clearly, and do they all help to fulfill the overarching objective of the study?
- Are the research design, methods and data/materials appropriate to answer the research questions? Is it clear how the study has been carried out? Are the methodological choices reasonable and well argued for?
- Are the analyses and results clear and do they address the research questions posed? Do the conclusions follow from the analysis? What are the possible implications of the results? Does the author discuss these?

To take on the role of the opponent in one seminar is mandatory, and the performance is graded as either Pass (G) or Fail (U). If the opponent's performance gets the grade Fail, they will have to submit written comments on the thesis they are evaluating.

After the conversation between opponent and respondent has concluded, the examiner will conduct an oral examination with the author. The examiner will ask various questions to the respondent, who will have the opportunity to answer. The oral examination will last about 30 minutes. The questions may vary depending on the thesis content and how the conversation between respondent and opponent unfolded, but may, for example, concern the literature on which the thesis is based, the research problem, the material and methodological choices, policy implications of the study's results, or how future studies could build on the work carried out. The purpose of the questioning is to give the author the opportunity to demonstrate that they wrote the thesis independently and that the student can reason about both theoretical and empirical aspects and implications of their own investigation. The oral examination is graded as Pass (G) or Fail (U).

After the open parts of the seminar, all participants leave the room except for the opponent and the author. The examiner first communicates the grade for the oral examination to the opponent, who then exits. Next, the author receives their grade. The oral examination grade is given first, and only if it is a Pass will the grade for the thesis be announced.

5. Assessment and grading

Progress toward the learning outcomes will be assessed through the Master's thesis and the student's performance at the final seminar, where students present and defend their work. In the final seminar the student will also act as opponent on another student's thesis. In addition to this the student is expected to participate actively in the discussions of other students' theses.

A. Grades

The grading scale comprises: Pass with Distinction (VG), Pass (G) and Fail (U).

The grades Fail (U), Pass (G), and Pass with Distinction (VG) are used for the written examination, while the grades Fail (U) and Pass (G) are used for the oral examination and for the opposition. All grades are combined following an assessment of both the written thesis and the oral examination. To achieve VG for the entire degree course, the student must obtain G for the opposition, VG for the thesis, and G for the oral examination. To achieve G for the course, the student must obtain G for the opposition, G for the thesis, and G for the oral examination.

Each thesis is evaluated by two teachers who jointly decide the grade: one is the examiner, who chairs the seminar, and one is co-examiner. The criteria for the grading of the thesis are provided in Table 1 below. In order to achieve Pass all eight criteria for Pass must be fulfilled. After the seminar students receive a written evaluation form (based on the criteria in Table 1) where the grade is motivated.

The criteria for the grading of the oral examination are provided in Table 2 below.

B. Screening process and Pass after revisions versus Fail

Upon submission, all theses undergo a preliminary screening. This means that the thesis is reviewed by the examiner and the co-examiner to determine whether it is sufficiently complete to proceed to examination. If the thesis is deemed not ready for seminar discussion the student will be contacted prior to the publication of the schedule and asked that the thesis be withdrawn. This procedure is in place to prevent students from receiving a failing grade on the written thesis at the seminar. However, it remains possible that a thesis presented after screening may still require a supplementary assignment following the seminar, meaning that the thesis is not immediately approved at that stage.

If the examiner and co-examiner judge that minor revisions are needed to raise the thesis to the standard of a passing grade, the student gets one opportunity to revise and resubmit the thesis. The examiner will provide the student with clear written feedback regarding what needs to be done to the thesis such that it can receive a passing grade. The required changes should be of a scope and scale that they can be addressed and remedied in approximately one week's time. The revised thesis must be submitted to the designated folder on Canvas within two weeks of receiving written feedback. If the thesis is not resubmitted, or the revision is considered insufficient to motivate the grade Pass, the thesis gets the grade Fail. If the thesis gets the grade Fail after revisions, the student will be referred to the next submission period, at which point they must resubmit their thesis, participate in a new seminar, undergo oral examination again, and act as opponent.

If the student receives a Fail (U) on the oral examination during the seminar, they will be offered a re-examination opportunity with the examiner, lasting a maximum of 30 minutes. This new opportunity will take place within two weeks of the original examination. If the grade for the oral re-examination is still Fail (U), the student will be referred to the next submission period, at which point they must resubmit their thesis, participate in a new seminar, undergo oral examination again, and act as opponent.

The thesis is assessed based on the following grading criteria:

Table 1. Summary of grading criteria for the Master's thesis

	Fail	Pass	Pass with Distinction
Research problem	A research problem is not clearly presented, or is not linked to the rest of the thesis.	The research problem is original and relevant to research and policy debates, and guides the rest of the thesis.	The research problem is original and highly relevant to research and policy debates, and guides the rest of the thesis.
Theory and previous research	Discussion of previous research lacking or not relevant to the research problem.	Clear presentation of previous research relevant to the research problem. Clear and appropriate definitions of key concepts.	Thorough, independent and clear presentation of previous research relevant to the research problem. Clear and appropriate definitions of key concepts.
Research questions	Unclear or not set in relation to previous research.	Clearly formulated and linked to previous research.	Clearly formulated, and justified and explained in terms of previous research.
Methodological approach and design	Research methods or design insufficiently discussed or not suitable for answering the research questions.	Sound and suitable for answering the research questions. Methodological choices described, discussed and justified.	Clearly sound and highly suitable for answering the research questions. Methodological choices clearly described, discussed and justified.
Data and material	Selection and evaluation of data and material falls short of scientific standards or not discussed at all.	Relevant to theory and clearly presented. Discussion of strengths and limitations of the data.	Highly relevant to theory and clearly presented. Insightful discussion of strengths and limitations of the data.
Results	Research questions not answered in a clear manner, or answers not set in relation to the research problem.	Thorough exploration of the research questions. The research questions are given clear answers, which are explicitly related to the research problem.	Thorough and in-depth exploration of the research questions. The research questions are given clear and thorough answers, which are explicitly related to the research problem.
Analysis and conclusions	Unclear or does not demonstrate analytical skills and/or reflective scientific approach to the study.	Demonstrate analytical skills and reflective scientific approach to the study.	Demonstrate strong analytical skills and an independent and reflective scientific approach to the study.
Language, citations and references	Poor use of language or incorrect use of citations and references.	Good use of language. Correct citation technique and use of references.	Very good use of language. Correct citation technique and use of references.

The oral examination is assessed based on the following grading criteria:

Table 2. Summary of grading criteria for oral examination

	Fail (U)	Pass (G)
Scientific problem and theoretical foundation	The student is unable to explain and justify how their own study builds on the literature referenced in the thesis, or what the key points are in the literature or theoretical framework on which the thesis is based.	The student explains and justifies how their own study builds on the literature, clarifies how the study contributes to literature and theory, and can reason about key points in the literature and theory used in the thesis.
Method and material	The student is unable to explain and justify key methodological choices, why a certain type of material was selected, and lacks knowledge of the content of the material.	The student explains and justifies key methodological choices, reasons about why alternative methods were excluded, explains why a certain type of material was selected, and demonstrates good knowledge of the content of the chosen material.
Results and theoretical and empirical implications of the analysis	The student is unable to reason about the central results of the thesis, what the results mean for previous research or the theory used, or their policy implications.	The student reasons about the central results of the thesis, what the results mean for previous research or the theory used, and their policy implications.

6. Formal requirements

A. Language and length of the thesis

The thesis must be written in English.

The exact number of words should be noted on the title page of the thesis. Note that the word limit includes all parts of the thesis: frontpage, abstract, footnotes, references in text, bibliography, etc. The only exception is the Appendix, if there is one. The following word limits apply:

Course: SK2512 Master's Thesis, 15 credits, shall be between 6000 and 12 000 words

Course: SK2532, Master's Thesis, 30 credits, shall be between 6000 and **16 000 words**.

These limits are strict and a thesis that exceeds the word limit will not be evaluated.

B. Abstract

The thesis shall have an abstract of maximum 250 words. The abstract shall summarize the whole thesis in a condensed way, including research problem, methods and main findings. Include maximum five key words after the abstract (in a separate row below the abstract).

C. Submission guidelines

The thesis should be submitted on Canvas. Please submit two versions of the thesis: one in

PDF format and one in Word format. After the seminar, the student will be asked for permission to archive the thesis digitally at the University Library. The student will need to sign a form for this purpose, which is emailed along with the grade justification form.

D. What if I cannot submit on time?

If the student is unable to submit the thesis on time there will be other opportunities at later seminars. Normally, there is a seminar session each term, and additional ones in March and August. Note: Students that plan to submit to the seminar in August need to take into account that most supervisors are on holiday during the summer and meetings need to be agreed upon in advance.

E. Title page

Please use the template provided on Canvas.

F. Attempts to deceive during examinations

The thesis must comply with all the formal requirements of academic writing. The following information about attempts to deceive during examinations apply to the thesis course:

An attempt to deceive during examinations means that a student has attempted to give an impression of their performance in a written exam or some form of assessment that is not true. That is what is commonly referred to as cheating, or attempting to cheat. There are different kinds of attempts to deceive, such as plagiarism, prohibited aids and prohibited collaboration. Deception can also take other forms.

- **Plagiarism** means that a student has presented someone else's text or other material as if it were their own text or material.
- **Prohibited aid** means that a student has used aids, including AI, that were not permitted according to the instructions.
- **Prohibited collaboration** means that students have collaborated with each other in breach of the instructions.

Plagiarism: Copying material from the Internet, from books, journals, reports, or from a fellow student and then presenting it as one's own is strictly forbidden! Plagiarism is theft of someone else's work and will result in immediate fail of the assignment. Please note that the inclusion of a source in a bibliography list is not in itself sufficient attribution of another's work. In addition, unless it is a proper citation with a reference, any direct copying of text is forbidden. All submitted student work is screened with a program called Ouriginal, which compares a student's written work with published materials (including everything published on the internet) and all the work from prior students, to detect plagiarism. The material you have read and based your arguments and factual statements on should always be referenced using proper referencing technique. More information on references and how to avoid plagiarism can be found here: <https://studentportal.gu.se/english/help-and-guidance/search-read-write/reference-management-and-plagiarism>

Prohibited aid: All your submitted texts should be your own original writing, and not written by someone else or generated by AI (see AI-policy below). Unless there are specific instructions for the use of AI for an assignment, it should not be used and presented as your own text. The use of any tools to cheat during on campus exams (e.g. DISA) is also strictly forbidden.

Prohibited collaboration: students can discuss their work, but individual submissions must be your own original writing, and hence not too similar the work of others. Be extra careful to avoid using common notes from such collaborations.

Any kind of cheating on examinations is considered a serious offence. Proved or suspected cheating will be reported to the Disciplinary Committee of the University of Gothenburg, in accordance with the procedure of disciplinary matters at the department of political science. The consequences may be severe for a student if found guilty. A student may be suspended from classes and campus for a determined time-period (from 3 weeks to half a year), which will result in a temporary suspension of all financial aid (including CSN) and may jeopardize a student's residence permit status. More information on disciplinary matters, including plagiarism and its consequences, can be found here: <https://studentportal.gu.se/english/study-environment-and-rules/disciplinary-matters/>

G. AI-policy

Within this course, the use of AI tools is permitted for specific purposes, including troubleshooting or generating code (e.g., in Stata or R), assisting with the interpretation of results (such as regression coefficients), enhancing understanding of advanced statistical procedures, generating ideas for research topics, and improving the language and grammar of written work.

It is prohibited to use AI tools to generate text for your thesis. Examples include, but are not limited to, literature reviews, interpretations of results, and descriptions of methods. Doing so constitutes presenting someone else's text as your own and is therefore considered plagiarism. It is also prohibited to use AI tools to conduct data analysis. In other words, you cannot delegate the analytical work to AI; the responsibility for performing the analysis lies with you.

Always keep in mind that generative AI tools, such as ChatGPT, can produce incorrect or misleading information. They may suggest code that does not work, invent references that do not exist, and more. In addition, AI-generated texts often tend to be overly long, unfocused, and filled with complex words or sentences that add little real meaning. Academic writing should always be clear, concise, and to the point. The text you submit must be something you fully understand and can stand behind. You are responsible for every part of your work – incorrect facts, vague phrasing, misinterpretation of coefficients, or flawed code cannot be blamed on AI.

In your methods section, you must include a declaration of AI use, specifying if and how AI tools were used.

7. Additional information and resources

A. Qualtrics - web survey tool

The Faculty of Social Science pays the license for the Qualtrics which is a tool for creating online surveys and online survey experiments. The license is administrated by the SOM Institute at GU. To get Qualtrics, you need to ask your supervisor to contact Tilda Ekström at tilda.ekstrom@gu.se and ask for a license on your behalf. Your supervisor should provide your name and your GU email address and confirm that you are a thesis-writing student that needs a license for the program.

B. Helpful links

Academic writing: <https://studentportal.gu.se/english/help-and-guidance/academic-Language-and-writing>

C. Course evaluation

In relation to the seminar sessions in January, June and August there is a course evaluation form available at Canvas. Anyone who completes the evaluation will remain anonymous. It is very important for the long-term quality of the course that these evaluations are completed. The Department of Political Science strongly encourages all students to complete the evaluation.